

Session 1: Introduction to Hymnody

Purpose of This Series:

- A historical study of Christian hymnody
- Not hymn trivia or isolated hymn stories
- Goal: learn how to read and understand any hymn in the hymnal

Some Questions:

- Why do we sing at Mass?
 - Adds delight to prayer
 - Fosters unity of minds
 - Confers greater solemnity
- What is a hymn?
 - A hymn is a **prayer** that **says something** in a **beautiful** manner.

Session	Topic
1	Introduction to Hymnody
2	Early Church Song
3	Plainchant
4	The German Chorale
5	Reformed Hymnody
6	The Oxford Movement
7	Hymnody Today

The Basic Building Blocks of a Hymn:

- Text
 - The theological *meat* of a hymn
 - Includes **meter** and **rhyme scheme**:

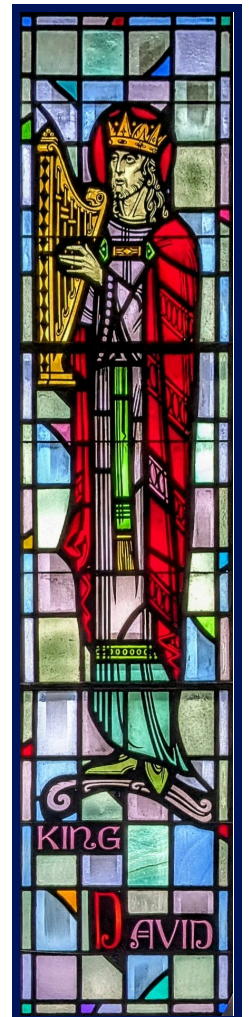
A-ma-zing grace, how sweet the sound (8)

That saved a wretch like me (6)

I once was lost, but now am found (8)

Was blind, but now I see (6)

- 8.6.8.6 meter, ABAB rhyme scheme.
- Tune
 - Must be singable by ordinary people
 - Must work for every stanza
 - Must stand on its own melodically
 - Tune names: NEW BRITAIN



The Text–Tune “Marriage”

- Relationship between text and tune compared to a marriage
 - Some pairings distort meaning
 - Some illuminate theology
- The tune should serve the text.

One Tune, Multiple Texts: **HYFRYDOL**

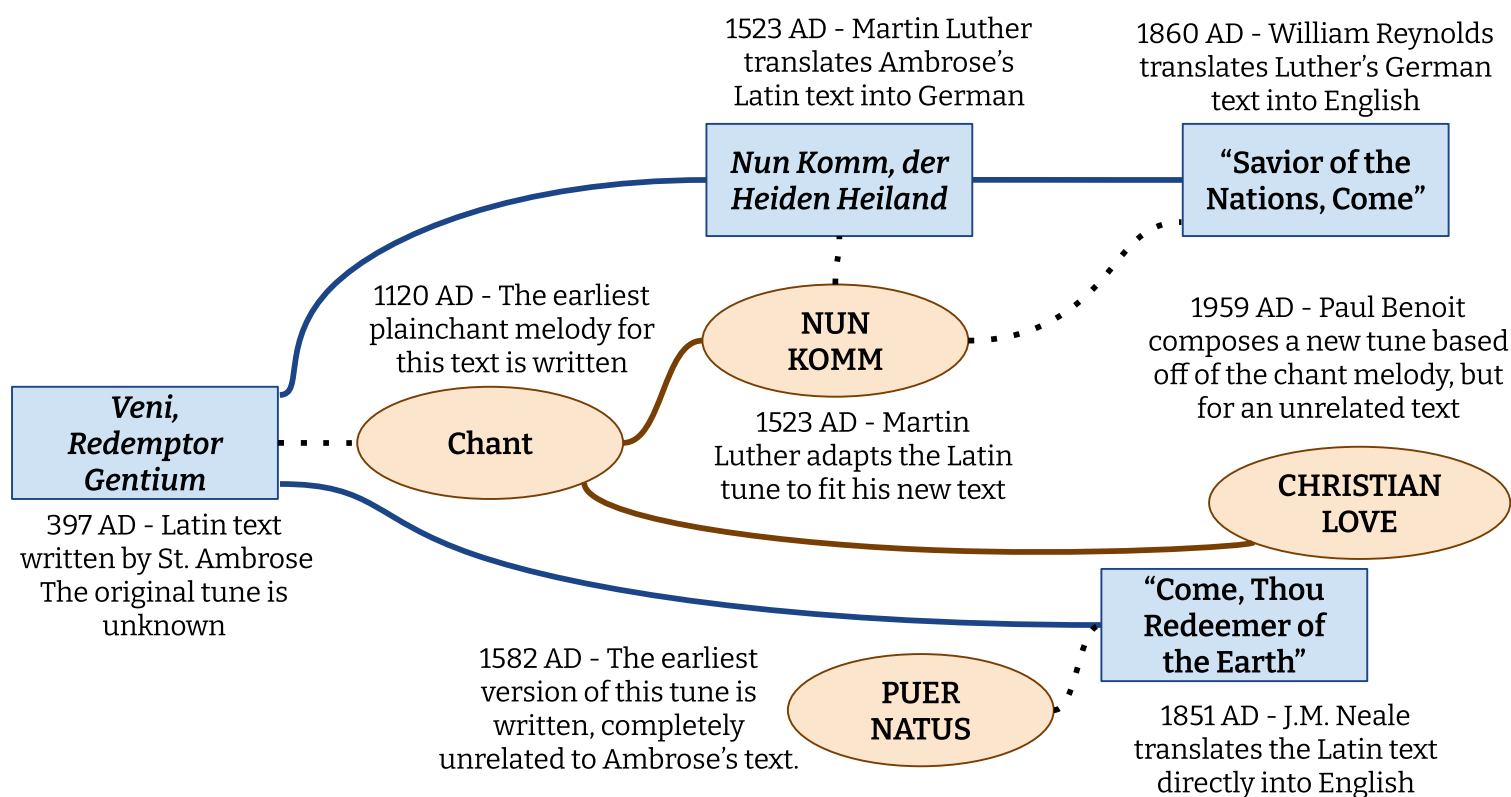
Love divine, all loves excelling,
joy of heaven to earth come down.
Fix in us Your humble dwellings,
All Your faithful mercies crown.

Alleluia! Sing to Jesus.
His the scepter, His the throne.
Alleluia! His the triumph,
His the victory alone.

One Text, Multiple Tunes: **“Away in a Manger”**

Away in a manger, no crib for a bed,
the little Lord Jesus laid down His sweet head.

A Case Study: *Veni Redemptor Gentium*



Stz. #	<i>Veni, Redemptor Gentium</i> St. Ambrose, 397	<i>Nun komm, der Heiden Heiland</i> Martin Luther, 1523
1	Veni, redemptor gentium; ostende partum Virginis; miretur omne saeculum: talis decet partus Deum.	Nun komm, der Heiden Heiland, der Jungfrauen Kind erkannt, dass sich wunder alle Welt, Gott solch Geburt ihm bestellt.
5	Egressus ejus a Patre, Regressus ejus ad Patrem: Excursus usque ad inferos Recursus ad sedem Dei.	Sein Lauf kam vom Vater her und kehrt wieder zum Vater, fuhr hinunter zu der Höll und wieder zu Gottes Stuhl.
7	Praesepe jam fulget tuum, Lumenque nox spirat novum, Quod nulla nox interpolet, Fideque jugi luceat.	Dein Krippen glänzt hell und klar, die Nacht gibt ein neu Licht dar. Dunkel muss nicht kommen drein, der Glaub bleib immer im Schein.
8	Sit, Christe, rex piissime, tibi Patrique gloria cum Spiritu Paraclito, in sempiterna saecula.	Lob sei Gott dem Vater g'ton; Lob sei Gott seim einigen Sohn, Lob sei Gott dem Heiligen Geist immer und in Ewigkeit.
Stz. #	<i>“Come, Thou Redeemer of the Earth”</i> John Mason Neale, 1851	<i>“Savior of the Nations, Come”</i> William Reynolds, 1860
1	Come, thou Redeemer of the earth, and manifest thy virgin-birth: let every age adoring fall; such birth befits the God of all.	Savior of the nations, come; Virgin's Son, here make Thy home! Marvel now, O heaven and earth, That the Lord chose such a birth.
5	From God the Father He proceeds, To God the Father back He speeds; His course He runs to death and hell, Returning on God's throne to dwell.	From the Father forth He came And returneth to the same, Captive leading death and hell High the song of triumph swell!
7	Thy cradle here shall glitter bright And darkness breathe a newer light, Where endless faith shall shine serene, And twilight never intervene.	Brightly doth Thy manger shine, Glorious is its light divine. Let not sin overcloud this light; Ever be our faith thus bright.
8	All praise, eternal Son, to Thee, whose advent sets Thy people free, whom, with the Father, we adore, and Holy Ghost, for evermore.	Praise to God the Father sing, Praise to God the Son, our King, Praise to God the Spirit be Ever and eternally.

The Four Voices in Hymnody

1. Doxological (Hymns of Praise)

- Most basic purpose of any hymn
- Focus on praising God or calling others to praise God
- Only describe qualities of God that honor Him directly

Angels We Have Heard on High
This Is the Feast of Victory
O God beyond All Praising
* Holy God, We Praise Thy Name
Now Thank We All Our God
Ye Watchers and Ye Holy Ones
Te Deum

2. Doctrinal (Hymns of Instruction)

- Teach aspects of the faith/God beyond just praise
- Take advantage of the teaching element of music and poetry
- Formal, third-person language

Of the Father's Love Begotten
* Hark! The Herald Angels Sing
Hail the Day That Sees Him Rise
Crown Him with Many Crowns
The Church's One Foundation
Profession of Faith (Nicene Creed)

3. Analogical (Story & Application Hymns)

- Tells a story & gives a practical lesson about that story
- Application asks either God or us to take action

Once in Royal David's City
As with Gladness Men of Old
* Lord, Who throughout These Forty
Days
O Sons and Daughters
For All the Saints

4. Experiential (Personal/emotional Hymns)

- Focus on the personal experience with God
- First person language
- Personal testimony of God's presence
- Don't necessarily describe any qualities of God Himself

Were You There
How Great Thou Art
O God, You Search Me
* Amazing Grace
How Can I Keep From Singing?
I Heard the Voice of Jesus Say
Magnificat (Lk. 1:46-55)

Doxological Hymn Example

“Holy God, We Praise Thy Name”

Text: Ignace Franz, 1774; tr. Clarence
Alphonsus Walworth, 1858

Tune: GROSSER GOTT, *Allgemeines
Katholisches Gesangbuch*, Vienna,
1774

1. Holy God, we praise Thy name;
Lord of all, we bow before Thee!
All on earth Thy scepter claim,
all in heav’n above adore Thee;
infinite Thy vast domain,
everlasting is Thy reign.
2. Hark! The loud celestial hymn
angel choirs above are raising;
cherubim and seraphim,
in unceasing chorus praising,
fill the heavens with sweet accord,
“Holy, holy, holy, Lord.”
3. Lo! The apostolic train
join the sacred name to hallow;
prophets swell the loud refrain,
and the white-robed martyrs follow;
and, from morn to set of sun,
through the Church the song goes on.
4. Holy Father, holy Son,
Holy Spirit, three we name Thee;
while in essence only one,
undivided God we claim Thee;
and, adoring, bend the knee,
while we own the mystery.
5. Thou art king of glory, Christ;
Son of God, yet born of Mary;
for us sinners sacrificed,

and to death a tributary;
first to break the bars of death,
Thou has opened heav’n to faith.

6. From Thy high celestial home,
judge of all, again returning;
we believe that Thou shalt come
in the dreaded doomsday morning
when Thy voice shall shake the earth
and the startled dead come forth.

7. Therefore do we pray Thee, Lord:
help Thy servants whom, redeeming
by Thy precious blood outpoured,
Thou hast saved from Satan’s
scheming.
Give to them eternal rest
in the glory of the blest.

8. Spare Thy people, Lord, we pray,
by a thousand snares surrounded;
keep us without sin today,
never let us be confounded.
Lo, I put my trust in Thee;
never, Lord, abandon me.

Questions:

How is God being praised in this
hymn?

For what is He being praised?

Who is being called to praise Him?

Doctrinal Hymn Example

“Hark! The Herald Angels Sing”

Text: Charles Wesley, 1739

Tune: MENDELSSOHN, Felix

Mendelssohn, 1840; arr. William
Hayman Cummings, 1855

1. Hark! The herald angels sing,
“Glory to the newborn king.
Peace on earth and mercy mild,
God and sinners reconciled!”
Joyful, all you nations, rise,
join the triumph of the skies;
with th’angelic host proclaim,
“Christ is born in Bethlehem!”

R/ Hark! The herald angels sing,
“Glory to the newborn King.”

2. Christ, by highest heav’n adored;
Christ, the everlasting Lord.
Late in time, behold Him come,
offspring of the virgin’s womb.
Veiled in flesh, the Godhead see;
hail th’incarnate deity,
pleased as man with man to dwell,
Jesus, our Emmanuel. R/

3. Hail the heav’n-born prince of
peace!
Hail the sun of righteousness!
Light and life to all He brings,
ris’n with healing in His wings.
Mild, He lays His glory by,
born that man no more may die,
born to raise us from the earth,
born to give us second birth. R/

Questions:

What qualities of God or the faith does
this hymn describe?

How is Scripture being used in this
hymn?

How does the hymn teach through
storytelling?

Analogical Hymn Example

“Lord, Who Throughout These Forty Days”

Text: Claudia Frances Hernaman, 1873

Tune: ST. FLAVIAN, *John Day's Psalter*,
London, 1562

1. Lord, who throughout these forty
days,
for us did fast and pray,
teach us with You to mourn our sins
and close by You to stay.

2. As You with Satan did contend,
and did the vict'ry win,
O give us strength in You to fight,
in You to conquer sin.

3. As You did hunger bear and thirst,
so teach us, gracious Lord,
to die to self and always live
by Your most holy Word.

4. And through these days of
penitence,
and through Your passiontide,
forevermore, in life and death,
O Lord, with us abide.

5. Abide with us that when this life
of suffering is past,
an Easter of unending joy
we may attain at last!

Questions:

What is the story that the hymn is
telling?

How does the hymn relate that story to
our experience?

What does the hymn ask of us? Of
God?

Experiential Hymn Example

“Amazing Grace”

Text: John Newton, 1779

Tune: NEW BRITAIN, *Columbian*

Harmony, Cincinnati, 1829

1. Amazing grace! How sweet the
 sound
that saved a wretch like me!
I once was lost, but now am found;
was blind, but now I see.
2. ‘Twas grace that taught my heart to
 fear,
and grace my fears relieved;
how precious did that grace appear
the hour I first believed!
3. The Lord has promised good to me,
His Word my hope secures;
He will my shield and portion be
as long as life endures.
4. Through many dangers, toils, and
 snares,
I have already come;
‘tis grace has brought me safe thus far,
and grace will lead me home.
5. When we’ve been there ten
 thousand years,
bright shining as the sun,
we’ve no less days to sing God’s praise
than when we’d first begun.

Questions:

What is the experience that caused
this personal reaction?

What is the personal reaction being
described?

How does the hymn use emotional
imagery to deepen its meaning?